PODCAST GUEST STORY PACK · SOUTH AFRICA · 2026

Not slop. A system.

How an Alberton producer built a human-led way of making music with AI, released an album he says was South Africa's first AI album, and became a test case for the country's blank AI music rulebook.



Justin Erasmus

Hybrid music producer · Founder, AlgoRythm Hybrid Music Production · Creator of the hybrid artist **Prismatic Wave**

AS FEATURED IN

TechCentral

"AI music is here and the South African rulebook is blank"
by Fanie van Rooyen · 19 October 2026

AS HEARD ON

SAfm

Radio interview · 30 October 2026
The National Briefing with Cathy Mohlahlana

12 tracks on *Echo Of The Streets*, dated 11 Feb 2025 on Spotify & Apple Music

4 stages in the AlgoRythm Hybrid Music Framework

2 rights bodies: SAMRO and SAMPRA member

WHERE THE STORY STARTS

The story starts with a machine

In 1980 a drum machine arrived that did not sound like real drums. It flopped, then it helped rewrite popular music. Justin Erasmus believes AI is on the same road, and he wants a human hand on the wheel.

In 1980, Roland put a box of analog circuits on sale and called it the TR-808 Rhythm Composer. It was built to keep time for musicians, and it did not sound like a drummer. Critics complained that its kick, snare and handclaps sounded nothing like real drums. Musicians worried that machines like it would put drummers out of work. By Roland's own account, it was not a commercial success.

Then something nobody planned happened. Once it turned up cheaply on the second-hand market, the 808 fell into the hands of people who heard its strangeness as a feature, not a fault. In 1982 it sat at the heart of Afrika Bambaataa and the Soulsonic Force's *Planet Rock* and Marvin Gaye's *Sexual Healing*. In 2008 Kanye West named an album after it: *808s & Heartbreak*. Roland now describes the 808 as a backbone of hip-hop and trap, and an influence on electro, techno and house. **The flop became the foundation.**



"Back in the day... they called it cheating." Today, it shaped hip-hop as we know it.

Poster artwork by Justin Erasmus for AlgoRythm. A dramatisation of the mood, not a historical quote.

The fear is older than the 808. In 1906, John Philip Sousa's essay *The Menace of Mechanical Music* warned that recordings and self-playing instruments could stand in for human skill, and he worried about composers' royalties too. In 1921, *Ladies' Home Journal* published an article blaming jazz for immorality, rhetoric soaked in prejudice that history has rightly thrown out. Jazz is an art form, not a gadget, but the reflex was the same: the new sound was treated as a threat before it was heard as music. When Bob Dylan played an electric set at the Newport Folk Festival in 1965 there were cheers and boos, and people still argue about whether the boos were about the electric turn, the poor sound or the short set.

THE PATTERN, AT A GLANCE

1906
Recorded music: a "mechanical" threat to skill
Now: everyday listening

1921
Jazz blamed for immorality
Now: a celebrated art

1965
Newport: cheers and boos for electric Dylan
Now: an iconic turning point

1980
The 808: "not real drums"
Now: the backbone of hip-hop and trap

1982
Synths: one London MU branch votes for a ban
Now: a foundation of EDM

1991
Sampling: an injunction and "Thou shalt not steal"
Now: an art form. Rights still matter

1998 / 2009
Auto-Tune: *Believe*, then *D.O.A.*
Now: a lasting pop language

2026
AI: the same argument, a new tool
Next: a rights negotiation

History is repeating itself.

Every tool that changed music was first written off as fake, as cheating or as a fad. Then it changed the sound of the world. AI is on the same path.

THE 808 DRUM MACHINE

Then: not real drums. A commercial flop in the early 1980s.

Now: the backbone of hip-hop and trap, and an influence on electro, techno and house.

THE SYNTHESIZER

Then: a threat to real players. In 1982 one London Musicians' Union branch voted to ban it.

Now: a foundation of EDM, house and modern pop.

THE SAMPLER

Then: theft, not music. A 1991 US ruling opened with "Thou shalt not steal."

Now: an art form at the heart of hip-hop. Permission still matters.

THE DIGITAL AUDIO WORKSTATION

Then: dehumanising. A 2008 opinion piece said Pro Tools was destroying music.

Now: the studio on every laptop. Amapiano's log drum began as an FL Studio preset.

Each time, musicians and critics frowned. To many it felt like cheating, and plenty said it would never last. Each time, the tool outlived the argument and reshaped whole genres: hip-hop, trap, EDM, house, pop and, at home, amapiano, built by township producers on home computers. The sound nobody trusted became the sound everybody danced to.

Now it's AI's turn.

The reaction has followed the script: it does not sound real, it will never take off. The evidence is already moving the other way. In a 2025 Deezer and Ipsos blind test of 9,000 people in eight countries, 97% could not correctly pick out which of three tracks were fully AI-generated. In a Sound On Sound survey commissioned by Sonarworks, around one in five of almost 1,200 music creators said they use AI regularly. And Grammy-winning producer Timbaland has openly embraced it: in 2025 he launched Stage Zero, an AI entertainment company, with its first AI artist, TaTa, built from his own demos and human-written lyrics.

The 808, the synth, the sampler and the DAW never left the studio. Justin's bet: AI is here to stay.

Pioneering hybrid music from Alberton

From Alberton, a small town in Gauteng far from the big studios, Justin Erasmus is building that future. His Hybrid Music Production Framework keeps people in charge at both ends: human concept, AI-assisted generation, human curation, then human production and delivery. He writes his own lyrics, he is a SAMRO and SAMPRA member, and he aims for hybrid music that sounds authentic next to any traditionally made record. Working with artists starts with consent: Congolese rapper Noko P agreed to have his voice used on one original amapiano track. Release by release, he is changing how people hear AI music: not as slop, but as a new instrument in human hands.

> **"This is another leap. Not a passing trick. I believe every artist will use AI in some form in the years ahead."**
>
> Justin Erasmus. His conviction, not a proven forecast.

Evolve or dissolve.

Justin's three-word thesis, and the question for your show: what can the 808 teach us about AI, and where must the human still lead?

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THE STORYLINE

From an Alberton studio to the centre of South Africa's AI music debate

Every good episode needs an arc. Justin's has a bold claim, a race for "first", a rights question nobody has fully answered yet, and a producer who insists the human is still in charge.

2023

The studio

Justin Erasmus founds **AlgoRythm Hybrid Music Production** in Alberton, Gauteng: music, beats, jingles and soundtracks made with AI under human creative direction.

11 FEB 2025

The album

Echo Of The Streets, a 12-track hip-hop album by his hybrid artist **Prismatic Wave**, goes live. Spotify and Apple Music date it 11 February 2025. Justin says it was South Africa's first AI album.

LATER IN 2025

The race for "first"

A later 2025 album is widely reported as South Africa's first AI album. TechCentral would later report that the platforms date Justin's album "more than seven months before" it.

19 OCT 2026

The profile

TechCentral's Fanie van Rooyen profiles Justin as a test case under SAMRO's new AI-disclosure rules in "AI music is here and the South African rulebook is blank".

30 OCT 2026

On air

Justin talks hybrid music on **SAfm The National Briefing with Cathy Mohlahlana**. Next: the podcast conversation.



Echo Of The Streets · Prismatic Wave
12 tracks · hip-hop · 11 Feb 2025
Cover art via Spotify listing

ALONG THE WAY

A documented method. He sets out the AlgoRythm Framework in a 2025 white paper.

Rights membership. He joins SAMRO and SAMPRA, he says by presenting his process and the substantial human work in it.

A release run. By his own count: 11 albums and 5 EPs in 13 months, plus 20 singles.

MYTH VS REALITY

Why human-led hybrid music isn't "slop"

"AI slop" describes content where nobody is steering. Justin's work starts and ends with a human, and he can walk you through where the human decisions happen.

MYTH

~~"It's one prompt and one click."~~

REALITY

His process starts and ends with a human. A human sets the concept, AI assists with generation, and a human curates, produces and delivers the final master.

MYTH

~~"The AI is the artist."~~

REALITY

Justin writes his own lyrics. AI is a tool, not the artist. Prismatic Wave is a hybrid artist identity he created and directs.

MYTH

~~"There's no human work worth protecting."~~

REALITY

He is a SAMRO and SAMPRA member, and says he got membership by presenting his process and the substantial human work in it.

MYTH

~~"Volume means no care."~~

ASK HIM

How do the four stages hold up across his release run (11 albums and 5 EPs in 13 months, by his count), and where do the human decisions sit?

THE ALGORYTHM 4-STAGE HYBRID MUSIC FRAMEWORK

01
Concept
Human vision + AI exploration
HUMAN-LED

02
Generation
AI-assisted creation
AI AS TOOL

03
Human Curation
Producer intervention
HUMAN-LED

04
Production & Delivery
Final hybrid master
HUMAN-LED

HUMAN → AI → HUMAN → AUDIENCE

ON SAfm SAfm, The National Briefing with Cathy Mohlahlana, 30 October 2026 · part of the SABC's research into AI in music

> **"I'm not looking at it as AI music. I'm looking at it as hybrid music… a combination of human creativity and human intuition."**

> **"…the human curation… the creative direction that you're steering the AI in, rather than simply accepting whatever comes out."**

THE RULEBOOK DEBATE

The rulebook is blank. Justin is a test case.

AS FEATURED IN TECHCENTRAL
19 OCTOBER 2026

“AI music is here and the South African rulebook is blank”

by Fanie van Rooyen

TechCentral profiled Justin as a **test case under SAMRO’s new AI-disclosure rules**.

It reported that Spotify and Apple Music date *Echo Of The Streets* to 11 February 2025, **“more than seven months before”** a later 2025 album widely reported as South Africa’s first AI album.

Read it: https://techcentral.co.za/ai-music-is-here-and-the-south-african-rulebook-is-blank/287431/

Why it matters to South African creators

01

What counts as human?

Where does assistance end and authorship begin? Justin’s answer is a documented, four-stage process with humans at both ends.

02

How should disclosure work?

With SAMRO introducing AI-disclosure rules, creators need to know what to declare and how. Justin is living that question now.

03

Who gets paid?

Composition and recording rights (SAMRO and SAMPRA) are where the money question lands for AI-assisted music.

04

Who was first, and who keeps the record?

Platform dates against headlines: a live case study in how South Africa’s AI music history gets written.

WHY HE’S THE RIGHT GUEST

- **He’s inside the system.** A SAMRO and SAMPRA member releasing AI-assisted music.
- **He can show his working.** The framework is written up in his 2025 white paper.
- **He has the receipts.** Platform-dated releases and a TechCentral profile.
- **He’s fresh off air.** SAfm interview, 30 October 2026 **The National Briefing with Cathy Mohlahlana**.

FOR THE HOST

10 questions that make a great episode

Use them as written or as a starting point. Justin is happy to go deep on the tech, the business or the culture.

01 ORIGIN You say *Echo Of The Streets* was South Africa's first AI album. Take us back to 11 February 2025. How did it come together?

02 ORIGIN A later 2025 album was widely reported as the country's first. What was it like watching that story play out?

03 THE NARRATIVE People call AI music "slop". What do you say to them, and where do you think they're right?

04 THE PROCESS Walk us through the four stages. Where exactly does the human come in?

05 THE PROCESS You write your own lyrics. What does AI do in your studio, and what does it never do?

06 IDENTITY Who is Prismatic Wave, and why create a hybrid artist identity?

07 RIGHTS How did you get SAMRO and SAMPRA membership? What did you have to show them?

08 RIGHTS TechCentral called South Africa's rulebook blank. What should AI-disclosure rules get right for creators?

09 CRAFT By your count, 11 albums and 5 EPs in 13 months, plus 20 singles. How do you protect quality and identity at that pace?

10 BUSINESS What does a hybrid production company in Alberton actually do for artists, brands and content creators?

Tech & AI shows

The framework, the tools, the human-in-the-loop

Music & culture shows

Prismatic Wave, the "first" debate, the slop narrative

Business & creator shows

Building AlgoRythm, rights, royalties, release strategy

ABOUT THE GUEST

Justin Erasmus



Hybrid music producer from Alberton, Gauteng, and founder of **AlgoRythm Hybrid Music Production** (founded 2023).

He created the hybrid artist **Prismatic Wave**, behind the 12-track hip-hop album *Echo Of The Streets* (dated 11 February 2025 on Spotify and Apple Music), and the **AlgoRythm 4-Stage Hybrid Music Framework**: Concept, Generation, Human Curation, Production & Delivery.

He is a SAMRO and SAMPRA member. He writes his own lyrics and treats AI as a tool, not the artist.

- Hybrid music production
- Beat production
- Commercial jingles
- AI-assisted songwriting
- Music for content creators
- Artist development

AS FEATURED IN

TechCentral · 19 Oct 2026

AS HEARD ON

SAfm · 30 Oct 2026 · **The National Briefing with Cathy Mohlahlana**

AVAILABLE FOR

Podcasts, interviews, radio, TV, expert comment

Book Justin for your show

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Listen first: *Echo Of The Streets* by Prismatic Wave is on Spotify and Apple Music. **Read:** Justin Ian Erasmus, "The AlgoRythm Framework: A White Paper on the Hybrid Music Production Process" (2025), Academia.edu.



AI creates possibilities. Human creativity gives them identity.